ALAGAPPA UNIVERSITY

(Accredited with "A+" Grade by NAAC (CGPA:3.64) in the Third Cycle & Graded as Category-I University and Granted Autonomy by MHRD-UGC)

KARAIKUDI – 630 003

Date: 6.11.2019

A Two-Day "International Conference on Addiction to Social Media and its Impact on Family, Youth and Children" was held at Alagappa University, Karaikudi on 05th and 06th November 2019. The Department of Social Work organised the conference under the sponsorship of RUSA phase 2.0 scheme.

While welcoming the gathering Prof. K.R.Murugan, Dean, Faculty of Arts, said in recent times youth use electronic gadgets excessively to access social media which impact negatively on their psyche and stated that the objective of the conference is to focus on the impact of social media addiction on family, youth and children and find out ways towards healthy use of social media for better familial and social relations. "Disconnect to Connect" was indeed the key theme of the conference. He added that 60 research papers have been received for presentation in the conference and it was attended by more than 200 participants which interestingly included 100 adolescent school students.

Presiding over the inaugural session of the conference Prof. H. Gurumallesh Prabhu, Registrar, Alagappa university, recalled the remarkable technological advancement in the last 50 years and referred to the positive features of social media such as whatsapp, facebook and other media sites, which helped to get required information in a fraction of a second but at the same time he warned how the excessive usage of social media by children and students has resulted in the decline of their academic performance and creative visualisation.

Inaugurating the conference Prof. Mojca Pajnik, Department of Media and Communication , University of Ljubljana, Slovenia, said that according a survey conducted by the Internatioanl telecommunication Union in 2017 71% of the youth (15 to 24 years) are the active users of social media compared to 48% of the general population. She emphasized that social media could be used effectively and safely and it is unfair to blame the social media alone for all kinds of social disorder. She added : "Think critically and teach the younger generation the fair and responsible ways of utilizing the technological development. She also said that it is the duty of parents and teachers to monitor the online activities of youth and children and make them aware of the risk involved in using them without self control. Cyber bullying and Selfie culture have become crucial issues today posing threads to women and children.

In his special address Prof. Rachmat Hidayat of University of Jember, Indonesia, listed out three major symptoms and behaviour of the social media addicts and said that addicts check their mobile phones every few minutes for any notification or information posted through different social media sites. They announce to the world through the media what they are doing right from brushing their teeth in the morning and whatever they do till they go to sleep during late night. When they have no access to internet or social media they feel that their world has crumbled. He added quoting researches done between 2012 and 2017 in the West that the excessive and multiple usage of social network is associated with the addicts experiencing psychological stress, anxiety, sleeping problems, feeling less happy and less confident and destabilized personal self control. All these impact and damage the addicts' personal relationship with others in the family and the society. He concluded his speech that self control is one of the most powerful mechanisms for maintaining social order and well being. He advised the users to logically think before posting any information on social media and they have to pose to themselves the following pertinent questions --- 1. Is it true? 2. Is it helpful? 3. Is it inspiring? 4. Is it necessary? and 5. Is it kind?. If answers are positive then they can post the information for people's consumption.

Prof. Gihani De Silva, Sabaragamuwa University of Sri Lanka, in her special address said that Sri Lanka too faced similar challenges and problems as in India owing to boundless use of social media. Besides many many advantages reaped by the users of social media, it could also destroy the inner peace of individuals when their confidential information is hacked by antisocial elements. Withdrawal symptom is one of the ill effects encountered by addicts who use social media in thoughtless ways.

Addressing the participants at the valedictory function of the conference held on 6.11.2019, Prof. N. Rajendran, Vice-Chancellor, mentioned that social media addiction is said to be a major behavioural disorder according to social scientists. This new addiction which has come to light currently has created a serious gap in social interaction and human relationship. It has led to strained social relationship among people and it could be solved by self control. He

said to his astonishment that he could see this problem prevailing even among elderly people. He exhorted the youth to be cautious while using the media; and said that indiscriminate use of social media will affect their mental, physical and social well being and retard their progress in education and employment, ultimately affecting their overall personality. He asked the researchers to suggest concrete solutions to solve this problem. He congratulated the organizers of this conference for making adolescent school children to participate in this meet.

Mr. J. Vignesh Sabarikiran, Adjunct Faculty, Department of Social Work, proposed a vote of thanks.

Prof.H.Gurumallesh Prabu
REGISTRAR